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Making smart investments in training: The devil is in the details

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Employee training and development is often one of an organization's largest budget items. Too often, however, organizations make decisions about how to invest that money without a systematic review of details that are critical in ensuring a return on that investment. There is a science to employee training and development. Informed by this science, by decades of experience implementing, customizing, and evaluating training programs, I offer a concrete and practical roadmap for making sound investments in training.

In the first major section, I offer questions that need to be asked and answered in order to estimate the likelihood that a commercial off-the-shelf product or service is likely to be as beneficial in your organization as it has been elsewhere. In the second section, I detail questions to be asked and answered in order to determine why a training program (homegrown or commercial off-the-shelf) that was once deemed successful in your organization appears to have become less effective over time, and what to do about it. In the final section of this article, I offer proactive steps that can be taken to set a new training program up for success and to protect the viability of an existing training program over time.

WILL IT WORK FOR US? INTER-ORGANIZATIONAL BENCHMARKING

Off-the-shelf training is usually less expensive than developing a homegrown training program from scratch. Moreover, there is typically an assumption that the training has already been proven to be effective for clients before you. Or has it? The first question you should ask a vendor when considering the purchase of a training product or service is, "What evidence exists to show that other organizations have benefitted from this training in the past?" And, how specifically did they benefit? What did the training change? Attitudes? Knowledge? Behavior?

Often such evidence comes from case studies. A case study is an in-depth examination of single situation over time. In the context of training validation, a case study follows a single group of employees from the start to the end of training and sometimes beyond. It may or may not involve the collection of any quantitative data. In fact, evidence of training effectiveness derived from case studies may be purely anecdotal (e.g., quotes from interviews with participants). When quantitative data is collected in a case study, the same group of people are compared pre-post training. Without a comparison to a comparable group of employees who did not receive the training (a control group) this leaves open the possibility that any pre-post changes observed may have occurred as a result of other factors (e.g., on-the-job experience) operating outside of the training context. Therefore, the most compelling evidence of training effectiveness comes from studies in which employees are randomly assigned to receive different types of training or to a control group and quantitative measures between the two groups are statistically compared. In addition to the type of studies conducted one should ask about the depth of the data collected.

Trainee reactions are the easiest and most frequently collected evidence of training effectiveness. Typically, reactions ask about trainees' enjoyment of training, their perceptions of the usefulness of training, and their confidence in using trained knowledge and skills on-the-job. Positive reactions to training have been linked to trainees' level of engagement and motivation to learn. However, they are by no means guarantees that learning has occurred. Thus, trainee reactions to a training program are only the first level (and the weakest evidence) of training effectiveness. The next level involves directly measuring *learning*. Learning criteria demonstrate that trainees' knowledge, attitudes, or skills have improved due to a training program (either compared to pre-training levels or to a control group).

Learning measures may involve surveys, written or psychomotor tests, and behavioral role plays or simulations. It is important to note that evidence of learning reflects what employees “can do” after training but not necessarily what they “will do.” Employees are often not able or willing to apply what they learn in training once back on their jobs. Therefore, a third level of training evaluation involves the assessment of on-the-job *behavior*. Measures of on-the-job behavior should be fairly specific to the content of training to be convincing. Again, pre-post comparisons may be made for a single group of employees or comparisons between separate groups of trained and untrained employees may have been made. Ultimately, an organization is interested in the final level of training evaluation: *results*. Results criteria reveal whether training impacted desired outcomes (e.g., sales or productivity). It is possible that employees both learn and apply knowledge or skills taught in training yet this does not impact an organization’s bottom line. When this occurs the organization has mis-identified their training needs and provided unnecessary training. Therefore, it is not enough to know that training has been impactful for other organizations. One must compare or “benchmark” their own organization relative to those for whom the training has been successful in the past. But what exactly should be benchmarked? The following sections describe important and often overlooked details. A list of specific questions to ask is presented in [Table 1](#).

Do Our Employees Have the Same Training Needs?

When benchmarking your employees’ training needs against the needs of those who have benefitted from a training product or service in the past, two questions need to be answered. First, how similar is the work performed by the two groups of employees? Second, how does your employees’ current standing on these knowledge, skills, and attitudes compare to the pre-training levels held by those who benefitted from a product or service previously?

A *job analysis* is a systematic study of the tasks performed on a particular job, the relative importance of those tasks, and the knowledge, skills, and attitudes that are critical for the performance of those tasks. The data from a job analysis can be used to compare the training needs of the employees in your organization who would receive a new product or service with those who benefitted from that training in the past. In this respect, it is important to benchmark both the underlying knowledge, skills, and attitudes requirements as well as the more superficial look and feel of the tasks performed. The “face validity” of course materials, or the appearance that they are directly relevant, from your trainees’ perspective can have a substantial impact on their motivation to engage and their ability to transfer what they learn. Therefore, it is relevant to ask a vendor how much customization of the training was done for or by their prior clients. It is important to note that this may also involve eliminating material that is irrelevant for a particular group of trainees.

As an example, I have found that when implementing the same team training program in different organizations, trainees react far more positively when I tailor terms to be

Table 1 Questions to ask before you purchase training from a vendor

- Does the vendor have any quantitative evidence that this program is effective? How many people participated? How many organizations?
- Did this come from a case study (pre-post comparison) or were trainees compared to a control group?
- How many people participated in the study (i.e., sample size)? How many organizations?
- What exactly has the training been shown to affect? Trainee reactions? Learning? On-the-job behavior? Organizational outcomes?
- What are the characteristics (e.g., age, culture, education, experience, skills) of the employees who participated in this training previously (especially those who provided quantitative data on its effectiveness)?
- In what ways do prior trainees differ from the employees who would potentially receive this training at our organization?
- What type of tasks/jobs were performed by employees who received this training previously (especially those who provided quantitative data on its effectiveness)?
- In what ways do these tasks/jobs differ from those performed by the employees who would be receiving the training in our organization?
- How exactly has this training been implemented in other organizations (e.g., internal marketing, length, number of sessions, opportunities to practice, customization of examples and terminology, type of instructor)?
- Has implementation varied? If so, does the vendor have reason to believe these variations lead to different levels of effectiveness?
- What modifications (e.g., internal marketing, length, instructor/trainer characteristics, number or type of practice opportunities, customization of materials) is our organization likely to make if we implement this training?
- Politically and practically speaking, how is your organization likely to implement the training?

consistent with the vocabulary they are accustomed to. Something as simple as using the word “team” when trainees are accustomed to being identified as a “crew” can send an immediate signal to participants that the training was not originally designed for, and may not be as relevant, to them.

Finally, when estimating how transportable an off-the-shelf training program will be to your organization, it is important to compare your targeted employees’ levels of knowledge, skills, and attitudes to that held prior to training by those who benefitted from a program in the past. For instance, how do the two groups of employees compare with respect to their prior formal education, job training, and experience? Is there any reason to be concerned that the training may be too easy or too difficult for your employees?

How Similarly Will We Implement the Training?

Assume you are persuaded that a particular training program has in fact led to improved knowledge, skills, or attitudes for others, and that your employees have the same training needs. The next step is to ask the question “Is it practically and politically realistic that your organization would deliver the training in the same manner that it has been delivered by those for whom the training was successful?” Again, the devil is in the details.

Benchmarking the details of training delivery should begin with determining how prior organizations have marketed the training internally. Internal marketing, the art of making employees aware of and excited about new initiatives, can significantly impact trainees' motivation to attend or to actively engage in that training. Therefore, it is relevant to ask a vendor how organizations that have successfully employed their training in the past communicated its purpose and value to prospective trainees. For instance, employees may have been told that a course was added to address deficiencies responsible for a recent incident or failure (e.g., loss of an important client, sexual harassment scandal)? Alternatively, they may have been told that the training was needed to prepare for an upcoming change or challenge (e.g., economy, merger, new product or equipment). Or perhaps, the training was introduced simply to keep up with their competitors who are using it.

It's also important to know what trainees were told about who advocated for the training. Was it a faction internal to the organization (e.g., union, management, HR, external government monitor), or perhaps an external regulatory agency? If your organization plans to internally market a training program in a manner that is different from the way it was done by organizations for whom the training was previously successful, this alone could cause you to have different results.

Beyond the internal marketing of a training program or service, it is important to benchmark details of the training process itself. It is common for organizations to modify the delivery of the training in ways that are more practical and less costly for them. Unfortunately, they almost always do this without data to suggest that the training will remain effective after these modifications are made. Typically, the first things to be cut or substantially reduced are opportunities for active practice (e.g., role-plays, simulations). This is because active practice adds significant time and labor (e.g., role-players) and these costs become multiplied as class size increases.

I found this to be the case for organizations that adopted an assertiveness training course my colleagues and I developed for junior aircrew members. The instructor guide we prepared for the course specifically stated that role-play was an essential component. However, we learned that when the training was implemented many instructors simply asked for volunteers to role play while the rest of the class watched. Observing and doing are not comparable activities when it comes to learning. Research has repeatedly shown that active practice producing verbal responses is critical for skill acquisition. So, reducing opportunities for practice in training is highly likely to reduce the effectiveness of that training. And, notably, those who volunteer to practice in front of the class are likely to be those who needed practice the least.

Another common way organizations modify a training course is to chop it up into multiple shorter sessions. This is typically done to avoid taking employees off of their jobs for an extended number of consecutive hours. However, doing so may also disrupt learning as it breaks up the intellectual flow and increases the likelihood that some participants will skip a session or two. It is rare that vendors have quantitative data that conclusively show how various changes to their training will impact learning. If they have

validation data at all, it is most likely from a single study where the training process was controlled. Therefore, when considering the purchase of a training program, ask the vendor for details regarding the manner in which the training was delivered when it's effectiveness was formally evaluated (if in fact it ever has been). It is also worth asking about common variations to the process that have been employed by other client organizations and whether the vendor has observed or received feedback that would indicate problems with any particular modification.

In sum, when estimating the likelihood that an off-the-shelf training product or service will be as effective for your organization as it has been for others you must consider how similarly you plan to implement the training. How will your internal marketing efforts compare to those adopted by previously satisfied customers? Is it likely that practical or political issues within your organization will require you to shorten, modify, or break up training in a different manner? Does your organization have the resources to customize the training to the degree it has been in the past?

WHY HAS OUR TRAINING STOPPED WORKING? INTRA-ORGANIZATIONAL BENCHMARKING

Whether a training program was purchased from a vendor or developed in house, it is fairly common for organizations to stop measuring its effectiveness once it has been deemed to be "effective." However, continual monitoring using quantitative metrics allows downward trends to be noted quickly (and agreed upon by multiple stakeholders). The sooner such trends are identified the easier it will be to pinpoint changes in process, instructors, timing, trainees, etc. that coincided with a drop in effectiveness. In the absence of such data, problems are likely to go on much longer without being noticed. This makes it far more difficult to disentangle the root cause since multiple factors are likely to have changed since a training program's inception. Ultimately, organizations often eliminate an entire training course when it only needed some updating; essentially throwing out the baby with the bathwater.

The first thing to determine when a training program appears to have become less effective is when exactly it stopped being as effective. This question can only be answered with confidence if successive cohorts of trainees have been assessed on the knowledge, skills, and attitudes targeted in training; and using the same metrics. Are trainees coming out of training with lower scores than they did in the past? Which metrics are lower? Trainee reactions? Learning? Transfer to the job? Results (e.g., sales or readiness for promotion)?

Once the pivot point has become clear, the next step is to do some intra-organizational benchmarking. What changed in close proximity to the drop in training effectiveness? The following sections describe some of the most common culprits. A list of specific questions is presented in [Table 2](#).

Have Our Training Needs Changed?

The nature of the work performed by employees holding the identical job title often changes slowly or in subtle but

Table 2 Questions to ask when training appears to have become less effective over time within an organization

- Based on what data was the training considered by your organization to be effective previously (Anecdotal evidence, quantitative data)? Trainee reactions? Learning? On-the-job behavior? Organizational outcomes? How confident are you in these data?
- Based on what data are you concerned that the training is no longer as effective as it once was? How confident are you in these data? When did effectiveness appear to drop?
- Have the tasks performed by employees taking this training changed over time such that different knowledge, skills, or attitudes (or different levels of these) are needed now?
- Has the look or feel of the projects/problems/customers changed over time? Do training materials appear outdated?
- Have there been changes in the applicant pool, selection tools, or cut-off scores used for hiring that may have affected employees' need for or preparedness for training?
- Has the timing of when employees receive this training (with respect to job tenure) changed?
- Have there been changes in other training programs upstream in the pipeline that may have affected employees needs or preparedness for the training?
- Has training implementation changed over time? (internal marketing, length, mode of delivery, number or type of practice opportunities, class size, relationships between class participants changed?)
- How do the instructors/trainers who delivered this training in the past differ from those who currently deliver the training? (e.g., credibility, familiarity, belief in the training, teaching style)?
- Has the length of time between training and opportunities for trainees to transfer training on-the-job changed?
- Have there been changes in the way that performance is evaluated or rewarded in your organization since the training was deemed effective?
- Have there been changes in leadership / supervision or the way in which leaders/supervisors are trained? Might these changes have reduced support for employees transferring training to their jobs?

important ways over time rendering the strategies taught in a training program obsolete or even counterproductive for later cohorts. For instance, task procedures may have changed or become streamlined, supporting technologies may have been added, or team members who were once co-located may now work virtually. Alternatively, it may be that the same skills are needed but the look and the feel of projects have changed. This could make case studies and demonstrations used in training to appear dated. Any of these changes to job demands could conceivably lead a training program that has been considered effective in the past to lose its effectiveness over time within the same organization.

Even if job demands have not changed it is possible that, over time, cohorts of newly hired employees have a greater or lesser need for a particular training program because they are hired with different levels of job-related knowledge, skills, and experience. This can occur due to changes in the qualifications of those in the applicant pool or changes in the criteria an organization uses to select its employees (i.e., more or less stringent). Complicating matters, in large organizations those responsible for employee recruitment and

selection are often not the same people who are responsible for training. In these cases, such changes in the competence of employees that are newly hired may not be automatically communicated even if they are noticed.

As an example, my colleagues and I learned that at one time the vast majority of new air traffic controllers hired by the FAA held private pilot's licenses. Over time, however, this became less pervasive. As a result, we identified a new need to augment existing team training to incorporate additional information about what goes on in the cockpit during emergency situations.

Employees' needs and preparedness for training can also be affected when an organization changes when or how frequently they offer a course. Again, this can cause a long-standing training program to become less effective because at the time employees receive the training they are more or less prepared for it. Similarly, the effectiveness of one training course can be negatively impacted when an organization adds, eliminates, reduces or delays giving another related or complementary course. The addition of a new (seemingly unique) course may eliminate the need for an existing one, or may inadvertently present employees with information or strategies that conflict with those presented in an existing one. Reducing, eliminating or delaying a course that normally precedes another can leave employees unprepared to learn from the downstream course. Such ripple effects are often not considered or are underestimated. In fact, when responsibility for training is distributed rather than centralized, changes in one program may not even be communicated to those responsible for another program.

In sum, if a longstanding training program is believed to have become less effective over time, it is important to consider whether employees' need for the training or their preparedness for the training has changed. This often occurs as a result of differences in the knowledge and skills possessed by new hires, or changes in the amount and type of experience employees have at the time they participate in the training. Finally, changes in other related courses upstream in the training pipeline can lead to redundancies, omissions, or conflicting guidance.

Have We Changed the Way We Implement the Training?

Often an abrupt change in training effectiveness will coincide with a changing of the guard with respect to those who deliver the training. This is particularly true when those who deliver a training program in its inception pass the baton. The initial instructors to deliver a training course tend to have been involved in advocating for the training need and/or developing the training content. Typically, this leads them to have an enthusiasm for and commitment to maintaining the integrity of the training process that is not shared by those who deliver the same course at a later date. When a new group of instructors take over there is always a danger that they will try to "fix something that isn't broken" simply to make the course their own. Although it is possible that training will be enhanced by such updates, it is also possible the training will become less effective. Thus, if a training program appears to have become less effective over

time, consider whether there has been a recent change in the individuals who deliver the training.

Changes in the physical and social training environment may also render training less effective over time. For instance, when training is delivered off-site employees typically have fewer work-related distractions competing for their attention than they do when it is delivered on-site. This can have a significant impact on engagement and ultimately learning. Other variables such as class size typically impact the opportunities that individual trainees have to participate in class discussions as well as their willingness to ask questions. Changes in the past or future relationships (or lack of) that exist between employees who attend training together can also have a significant impact on the training dynamic. For instance, training members of intact teams together can facilitate goal setting and planning for transfer to the job. It can also build cohesion and trust particularly if the content of training is interpersonal in nature. Coworkers who attend training together can serve as reminder cues and can hold one another accountable for transfer as well. Similarly, changes in the credibility (e.g., technical expertise) or the organizational relationship between the individual(s) who teaches a course (e.g., internal human resources, external consultant, managers) and those who take the course can affect trust and openness during training, which may lower learning outcomes.

For instance, much has been written about the growing gig economy, where workers engage in various forms of contingent work arrangements for a defined period of time without any long-term relationship with a particular business. Contingent employees who perform the same jobs that were previously performed by permanent employees may respond differently to the training provided to them. Additionally, if an organization chooses to employ contingent employees to provide training that was previously delivered by permanent organizational members, this may affect the dynamic between trainees and their trainers. As an example of this, over the past decade NASA has substantially increased their use of external contract employees to deliver training that was once delivered by an internal government employee.

Finally, it has become popular to deliver part or all of courses that were once solely face-to-face using some sort of distance learning technology. Although the cost savings associated with making such changes are easy to estimate, the costs in terms of training effectiveness are not. Therefore, organizations often have little or no guidance in determining what training objectives can be appropriately met in a distance learning environment. In an online setting, employees often have the freedom to break up lessons into pieces separated by enough time so as to interrupt the intellectual flow. They may also engage with an online training system in an environment that is full of distractions (e.g., kids, pets). To the extent that interaction between trainees and between trainees and a trainer are integral to learning, moving training to an online platform has a strong potential to reduce training effectiveness.

In sum, even subtle changes in the way that a training program is implemented could cause it to become less effective for your organization than it was previously. Organizations can be proactive about maintaining the integrity of a successful training program. Documenting the rationale for

decisions made regarding the content, methods, timing, etc. of a training program is critical in ensuring that new instructors do not modify the program in ways that make it less effective. Additionally, when there is frequent turnover of those responsible for delivering a training program organizations would do well to invest in a “train the trainer” course. At a minimum, this should include a video recording of the course given in its purest form for instructors to study.

Has Our Transfer Environment Changed?

All other factors being equal, it is possible for a training program to become less effective over time within the same organization simply because the transfer environment no longer motivates or enables employees to use what they have learned once back on their jobs. In this case, the training process itself may be just as effective at enhancing what employees “can do,” yet not what they “will do” after training. In this section, I highlight three aspects of the transfer environment that are most likely to change over time and to weaken the effects of training.

First, when it comes to job performance, you get what you measure. Employees are motivated to demonstrate behaviors that they are held accountable for and rewarded for. When they perceive a direct link between the content of training and the recognition and rewards they desire, applying what they learn in training becomes instrumental to their success. In this way, an organization’s performance appraisal and compensation policies partially determine whether employees will transfer what they have learned in training to their jobs. When changes are made to the criteria used to evaluate and compensate employees this has the potential to reduce the effectiveness of a particular training program. For instance, making a performance appraisal more outcome-focused weakens the perceived link between demonstrating specific behaviors or strategies and receiving desired rewards. Therefore, if a once successful training program appears to have become less effective over time, an organization should consider whether this may have occurred because training-related competencies are no longer being formally evaluated or rewarded.

Second, research has shown that the frequency and timing of opportunities employees have to practice their newly learned skills on-the-job partially determines how effective training will be. Knowledge and skills will often decay if they are not practiced. Moreover, motivation to attempt transfer is highest immediately following training. Changing when a particular training course is given to employees in the context of their professional development has the potential to reduce, increase, delay, or accelerate the opportunities they have to apply newly learned knowledge and skills on-the-job. For example, my colleagues and I found that new Navy officers benefitted more from classroom leadership training if they had been given some limited shipboard experience prior to that training than they did if the classroom training came before any shipboard experience. The officers reported that without some relevant on-the-job experience it was more difficult to visualize the concepts taught in the classroom training. In this way, the same training program may become more or less effective for consecutive cohorts of trainees if there is a change in the timing of when it is delivered.

Third, research has repeatedly demonstrated that supervisory support for the use of trained knowledge and skills on-the-job is a key determinant of transfer. In fact, employees are highly sensitive to informal cues that suggest what they learned in training is accepted and expected in their immediate work team. Supervisors cannot be effective at reinforcing transfer if they themselves are not familiar with the training their subordinates receive. If a previous cohort of supervisors participated in or perhaps even helped to develop a training program designed for their subordinates and a later cohort of supervisors did not, this could weaken the informal reinforcement of training transfer over time. In this way, significant managerial turnover in an organization could cause a once impactful training program to become less effective over time for subsequent cohorts of employees, simply because transfer of training is no longer supported by immediate supervisors.

In sum, when a training program appears to have become less effective for cohorts of trainees over time, it is important to compare past and present performance appraisal systems, supervisory staff and their commitment to the training, and opportunities that trainees have to apply what they have learned on-the-job. Such benchmarking may uncover the root cause for a drop in training effectiveness.

PROTECTING YOUR TRAINING INVESTMENTS

In this concluding section, I offer recommendations that will help you help your organization to make smart investments in training.

- 1 *Look Before You Leap!*
- 2 Always ask vendors to see quantitative evidence that their training products and services have benefitted other organizations in the past.
- 3 Ask about the kinds of work performed by those who have benefitted from the training before.
- 4 Ask vendors about variations in the way their products and services have been implemented in the past and whether there is reason to believe that these have impacted training effectiveness.
- 5 Customize off-the-shelf training materials by incorporating your organization-specific terminology and including concrete examples of how the trained knowledge or behavior can be applied in the day-to-day lives of your employees.
- 6 *Know Thyself!*

- 7 Measure critical knowledge, attitudes and skills as part of formal appraisal systems to determine which employees need what type of training.
- 8 Continually monitor training effectiveness so you have hard data to indicate when and if a training program has become less effective for new cohorts of employees.
- 9 *Connect the Dots!*
- 10 Create formal mechanisms for regular communication between those responsible for different training programs within the same pipeline.
- 11 Create formal mechanisms for making those responsible for training aware of changes in recruitment and selection that may affect the competencies (and thus training needs) of newly hired employees.
- 12 Consider the possible impact on training effectiveness before making changes to performance appraisal policies and procedures.
- 13 Consider the possible impact on training effectiveness when making changes to job design and workflow.
- 14 *Document Your Recipe for Success!*
- 15 Document the whys. Why was the training developed in the first place? Why were critical decisions made regarding training delivery (e.g., length, type of practice opportunities, when it will be offered and to whom)?
- 16 Develop train the trainer programs to ensure quality control.
- 17 Create procedures for documenting changes instructors make to the training process over time.
- 18 Set the stage for transfer of training!
- 19 Measure and reward employees for demonstrating the behaviors you train on-the-job.
- 20 Provide supervisors with training that is complementary to that being given to their direct reports.
- 21 Develop customized job aids that assist trainees in applying what they learned in training on their specific jobs.

Summary

Billions of dollars each year are spent on employee training and development. The present article was written to help organizational decision-makers to be more systematic in making and protecting those investments. I have made the case that “the devil is in the details” and highlighted a number of variables that are often overlooked when purchasing, modifying, or discontinuing a training program. Finally, I have offered a number of proactive measures that can be taken to improve the return on investments organizations make in training products and services.



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